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THE ANIMATED RAIL LIFE

Time, Tigers and More Mysteries

This chapter takes a look at the peculiarities that one had to deal with while travelling on trains in India in the first half of the twentieth century—from different time zones to the story of toilets on trains and from tigers arriving at halt stations to divine intervention. The narratives reproduced here depict the social scenes of the Indian Railways.

WHEN THE INDIAN RAILWAYS HAD DIFFERENT TIME ZONES

Simply speaking, the rising and setting of the sun signifies day and night, and when the sun is directly overhead, it is noon. The local time had been set since ancient times based on the sundial. The arrival and expansion of the railway network changed that. Time and speed being vital components of rail travel, the need was felt for a standardized time. The sundial or solar time became increasingly inconvenient as it differed with geographical longitudes, changing for every degree.

As the UK grew into an advanced maritime nation, British mariners kept at least one chronometer on Greenwich Mean Time (GMT) to calculate their longitude from the Greenwich Meridian, which was by convention considered to have 0° longitude, internationally adopted in the International Meridian Conference of 1884. [97]

The GMT was adopted across the island of Great Britain by the Railway Clearing House in 1847, and by almost all railway companies by